



Fiona Stanley Fremantle Hospitals Group

OFFICIAL

Procedure

Mental health status assessment in the community

Scope

Site	Service/Department/Unit	Disciplines
Fiona Stanley Hospital Fremantle Hospital	Mental Health Service	Medical, Nursing, Allied Health

1. Introduction

The purpose of this policy is to ensure that all mental health status assessments completed in the community are conducted by mental health clinicians where it is safe to do so. This document outlines the required processes for undertaking a mental health status assessment in the community in accordance with the Western Australian Department of Health [Community Mental Health Status Assessments: Role of Mental Health Clinicians Policy](#).

2. Terminology

Mental health status assessment	An assessment performed by a mental health clinician to determine the presence of a mental health problem or illness, if there is a significant risk to the person or another person if treatment is not provided, whether the person is well enough to make a decision about their own treatment and whether or not an involuntary treatment order is appropriate in the circumstances, or if there is a less restrictive way of providing treatment.
Mental health clinician	For the purpose of this procedure includes psychiatric registrars; consultant psychiatrists; authorised mental health practitioners; and community mental health multi-disciplinary team members

Inpatient treatment order	An order under the Mental Health Act 2014 where a person can be admitted to and detained at a hospital without informed consent being given in order to enable the person to be provided with treatment and detained.
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3. Procedure

3.1. Mental health status assessment

- Requests for a mental health status assessment may come from:
 - concerned persons
 - another organisation e.g. Non-Government Organisation
 - community member
 - health service staff
- Where health service staff identify concerns regarding the mental state of a consumer in the community, they must make a referral for the relevant mental health service in the relevant provider/catchment to undertake a community mental health status assessment. This assessment should be undertaken by a mental health clinician as soon as practicable.
- On receiving a request, the Mental Health Service will determine the form and urgency of assistance required through consultation with the requesting person/organisation. Assistance may include:
 - phone contact with consumer or personal support person
 - provision of mental health advice and/or coordination
 - home visit
 - requesting Western Australian (WA) Police assistance based on the patients assessed level of risk
- If the mental health clinician determines that a community mental health status assessment is not required, they must:
 - explain the reason for the decision to the requestor
 - document reason in the medical record
 - advise the relevant Team Leader/Consultant Psychiatrist of the reasons for the decision
- The Consultation Liaison (CL) Service may be contacted during business hours for assistance/advice regarding the relevant Mental Health Service to be contacted for a community mental health status assessment.

3.2. Assistance from Police

- In instances where a concerned person requesting assistance may struggle to escalate care, health service staff receiving the request for assistance must contact the ambulance or police, simply advising the caller to contact the ambulance or police is not adequate.
- Where a mental health clinician forms a reasonable belief that a consumer being treated in the community is at significant risk of harm to self or others (including mental health staff), the mental health clinician must take all appropriate steps to prevent significant harm and treat the matter as a high priority.
- Transport officer, ambulance services and police assistance must be requested as appropriate to the identified risk and clinical need.

WA Police Force assistance must only be requested when the consumer continues to pose a significant imminent risk of harm to themselves or to another person after the application of appropriate clinical management strategies to mitigate significant transport risks.

- The requesting mental health clinician must manage identified transport risks while awaiting attendance by the WA Police Force.
- The Mental Health Service will provide all required assistance to the WA Police, Ambulance service, the consumer and the family/carers.
- Mental Health Service staff will record all referrals to Police in PSOLIS using the Service event – Liaison police.

4. Compliance Monitoring

Programme Managers will evaluate compliance with this procedure in their areas by monitoring clinical incidents and complaints related to delays in responding to a deterioration in a consumer's mental state in the community

5. Related Policy Documents

- Department of Health:
 - [Community Mental Health Status Assessments: Role of Mental Health Clinicians Policy](#)
- SMHS:
 - [Discharge against medical advice and patient initiated early discharge](#)
 - [Acute response mental health emergencies/crises](#)

- FSFHG:
 - Did not attend: Mental health outpatient's appointment

6. Related Standards

- NSQHS Standards:
 - Comprehensive Care
 - Communicating for Safety
 - Recognising and Responding to Acute Deterioration
- Chief Psychiatrist's Standards for Clinical Care:
 - Assessment

7. Authorisation

EXECUTIVE SPONSOR: Service Director, Service 5					
Version	Date Issued	Compiled/Revised By	Committee/Consumer Group Consulted	Endorsed By	Revision due
1	06/2019	Clinical Nurse Specialist, Clinical Improvement	Service 5 SQR Committee	FSFHG Policy Committee	06/2022
2	07/2022	Clinical Nurse Specialist, Clinical Improvement	Service 5 SQR Committee	Service 5 SQR Committee	09/2025
3	02/2026	Clinical Nurse Specialist, Clinical Improvement	FH Clinical Governance Sub Committee	FH Clinical Governance Sub Committee	02/2029
4	03/2026	Clinical Nurse Specialist, Clinical Improvement	Minor amendment, no change to review date	FH Clinical Governance Sub Committee	02/2029